

## **ML Activities Suite** Classroom Activity Resource · MLL Engagement · K–12

**About This Resource:** This activities suite was designed to give teachers a ready-to-use bank of language-rich activities that support multilingual learners across all four language domains: listening, speaking, reading, and writing. Activities are organized by instructional purpose, so any content-area teacher can find something usable regardless of what they teach. Every activity includes tool recommendations for virtual settings.

**Four-domain framework:** Activities are mapped to speaking, listening, reading. This reflects the WIDA framework, which assesses language proficiency across all four domains separately. Teachers working with multilingual learners need to develop all four deliberately, and the suite makes it easy to see where any given activity fits.

**Tool integration as scaffolding:** Each activity includes specific platform recommendations — Nearpod, MagicSchool AI, Zoom, Google Docs. This was a design choice rooted in accessibility. Recommending a tool alongside an activity reduces the planning burden for teachers and ensures that the activity is not only engaging but also accessible for students at varying proficiency levels. A speaking activity paired with Nearpod Audio Record, for example, gives students a lower-stakes way to respond than speaking live in front of the class.

**Flexibility as a core principle:** Activities are intentionally open-ended enough to adapt across grade levels, proficiency levels, and content areas. The goal was not to prescribe exactly how each activity should run but to give teachers a strong enough foundation that they could make it their own.

# ML Activities Suite

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## Overview

The ML Activities Suite equips educators with practical, language-rich activities to support multilingual learners' development in listening, speaking, reading, and writing. This suite offers a diverse collection of interactive and culturally responsive activities that can be integrated into instruction using virtual tools like Nearpod, MagicSchool AI and Zoom. Activities are grouped by focus—like warmups, classroom culture, brain breaks, gamification and language domain—and are meant to be flexible, so any teacher can adapt and use them in their own way to help students feel included, supported, and confident in class.

## Warm Up Activities

|                   |                                                                                                                                                                         |
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| <b>Pictionary</b> | Show students a vocabulary word and give them 30 seconds to draw something that represents that word.<br><br><b>Tools to Try:</b> Virtual whiteboard or Nearpod Draw It |
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| <b>Sentence Scramble</b>    | <p>Display a sentence with the words out of order and have students work individually or in pairs to quickly rearrange them into the correct order.</p> <p><b>Tools to Try:</b> Class chat or virtual whiteboard</p>                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Hurrah-Boo!</b>          | <p>Ask your students to listen intently to statements you're about to make. If it's a nice statement, they say <i>hurrah!</i> If it's not so nice they say <i>boo!</i> Ex. "Everyone gets an ice cream...<i>hurrah!</i>" "Lunchtime is canceled... <i>Boo!</i>"</p>                                                                                                               |
| <b>Would you Rather?</b>    | <p>Ask a "Would you rather?" question related to a current theme or topic, and have students choose an answer. Then, ask them to explain their choice briefly.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Polling features in Zoom or Nearpod</p>                                                                                                                                                |
| <b>Two Truths and a Lie</b> | <p>Ask each student to write two true statements and one false one about themselves or related to a topic you've been discussing. The rest of the class guesses which is the lie.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Virtual whiteboard or polling features in Zoom or Nearpod</p>                                                                                                       |
| <b>Word Chain Game</b>      | <p>Start by giving a word, and the next student has to say a word that starts with the last letter of the previous word (e.g., "apple" → "elephant" → "tree").</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Class chat or virtual whiteboard</p>                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Odd One Out</b>          | <p>Provide students with a group of 3 to 5 words. In each group, all the words except one should belong to a certain category or share a common feature. The students' task is to identify the word that does not belong (the "odd one out"). Example: cat, dog, car, fish.</p>                                                                                                   |
| <b>Simon Says</b>           | <p>Back up from the camera and use materials around you that fit in the camera view. Give clear, concise directions, like "Simon says raise your right hand." Students should do the action. For added listening practice, do not always say "Simon says" or do a different action than the one you call out. Students who do the wrong action sit down until the next round.</p> |

## Building Classroom Culture

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| <b>Goal Setting</b> | <p>Set 3 goals with your students for a certain amount of time-- the week, the month or the unit! These can be personal goals, academic goals, content-related goals, and/or language goals.</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• 1 Goal for [Math] class</li> <li>• 1 Goal for learning English</li> <li>• 1 Goal for outside of class</li> </ul> |
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| <b>Virtual Show and Tell</b> | <p>Students take turns sharing an object from their home that is meaningful to them. They then explain why they chose the item and its importance in their lives. Another version of this that can be done on short notice is to have students share something they have with them in the classroom or to draw a picture of a meaningful item.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Virtual whiteboard</p> |
| <b>Short intros</b>          | <p>Give each student 60 seconds to introduce themselves. They can include information like their name, hobbies, favorite food, or a fun fact. To add a challenge, you can ask them to include specific vocabulary or sentence structures.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod Audio Record in open ended questions</p>                                                                            |
| <b>Personal Timeline</b>     | <p>Ask students to create a simple timeline of three to five important events in their life and share it with the class. This could include things like moving to a new city, learning a new skill, or attending a special event.</p>                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>2 by 2</b>                | <p>Pair up students and give them two minutes to get to know each other. After the two minutes, bring everyone back and have each student introduce their partner and share what they learned. Encourage students to practice note taking and asking questions during this activity too!</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Virtual whiteboard or open ended questions in Nearpod</p>                    |
| <b>My Ideal Day</b>          | <p>Ask students to describe what their ideal day would look like. They should explain what they would do, where they would go, and who they would be with. This can be done in pairs, small groups, or shared with the whole class.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod Audio Record in open ended questions</p>                                                                                  |
| <b>3 emojis</b>              | <p>Ask each student to choose <b>three emojis</b> that represent something about them — it could reflect their personality, interests, how they're feeling, or something they did recently. They can pick from the emojis available on their devices or from a provided list.</p> <p>Example: 😊 🏀 🍕</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Class chat or Nearpod Draw it</p>                                 |

## Brain Breaks

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| <b>Pencil balance</b> | <p>Ask students to balance a pencil (or any small object) on their finger for as long as possible. You can challenge them to see who can balance the object the longest. Put a timer on the screen.</p>                                                                                   |
| <b>Roll Dice</b>      | <p>Students will name things they see in the room based on the number rolled on some dice. Roll the dice virtually using a dice-rolling tool. You can increase the difficulty by adding special rules. Ex. All 4 words must start with the letter "a" or all 5 objects must be white.</p> |

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|                     | <b>Tools to try:</b> Virtual dice roller and virtual whiteboard                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| <b>The Hot Seat</b> | One student sits in the "hot seat" by sitting in front of the projector and facing out into the room. The teacher shows the class a word on the screen (but not to the student in the hot seat). The other students must give clues or descriptions without saying the word, and the student in the hot seat has to guess the word.                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Celebrity</b>    | The teacher (or students) selects a well-known celebrity or fictional character. The other students must ask yes/no questions to figure out the identity of the celebrity. Questions might include, "Is this person a singer?" or "Are they in movies?" The game continues until the celebrity is guessed.<br><br><b>Tools to try:</b> Virtual whiteboard                                                                                                                                                                             |
| <b>Telephone</b>    | The teacher whispers or privately sends a simple sentence to the first student via private message.<br>Example: "The cat is sitting under the tree."<br>The first student then whispers the sentence to the next student. This continues until the last student receives the message. When the message reaches the last student, they say the sentence out loud to the whole class. The teacher or the first student then reveals the original sentence, and the class can compare how much the sentence changed throughout the game. |
| <b>Tell me 5</b>    | The teacher gives a category, such as "Fruits, animals, things in a school or countries." The selected student (or group of students) must quickly name five items that belong to that category. They can either say their answers aloud or type them in the chat.<br><br><b>Tools to try:</b> Private/class chat, open ended question in Nearpod, or virtual whiteboard                                                                                                                                                              |

## Gamification

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| <b>Kahoot</b>              | <a href="https://kahoot.com/">https://kahoot.com/</a><br>Interactive quizzes for vocabulary, grammar, and comprehension. Students answer questions in real time, making learning competitive and fun.                                                                  |
| <b>GimKit</b>              | <a href="https://www.gimkit.com">https://www.gimkit.com</a><br>Similar to Kahoot but focuses more on earning "money" for correct answers. It's great for review games where students practice language skills while accumulating points.                               |
| <b>Wayground (Quizziz)</b> | <a href="https://wayground.com/?lng=en">https://wayground.com/?lng=en</a><br>Offers self-paced quizzes for students to practice grammar, vocabulary, or reading comprehension. Teachers can assign quizzes as homework or in-class activities with real-time feedback. |
| <b>Wordwall</b>            | <a href="https://wordwall.net/">https://wordwall.net/</a>                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

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|                   | Allows teachers to create interactive activities like matching games, word searches, or quizzes to practice ESL vocabulary or grammar. It's useful for both live classes and independent practice.                                                                                                      |
| <b>Go Noodle</b>  | <a href="https://www.gonoodle.com/">https://www.gonoodle.com/</a><br>Primarily a movement-based platform, it can be used for short brain breaks or energizers in between language lessons, helping students stay active and focused, especially younger learners.                                       |
| <b>Class Dojo</b> | <a href="https://www.classdojo.com/">https://www.classdojo.com/</a><br>A classroom management tool that helps track student behavior and engagement. In an ESL class, teachers can award points for participation, language use, teamwork, or completing assignments.                                   |
| <b>EdPuzzle</b>   | <a href="https://edpuzzle.com/">https://edpuzzle.com/</a><br>Students watch an educational video (e.g., on history, science) and answer embedded questions about the content as they listen. Combines visual and auditory learning to improve comprehension and recall of information for ESL students. |

## Activities by Language Domain

### Speaking

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| <b>Role-Playing</b>         | Students are paired or placed in small groups to act out real-life situations (e.g., at a restaurant, asking for help in a store). These scenarios can be tied to the content being covered.<br><br><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod Audio Record in open ended questions                                        |
| <b>Debates</b>              | Students are divided into teams to debate a specific topic related to the lesson (e.g., environmental issues, historical events). They must argue for or against a position using supporting evidence.                                                                                                       |
| <b>Discussion Circles</b>   | Small breakout groups discuss a reading, video, or topic from the lesson, sharing thoughts and opinions with sentence starters provided by the teacher (e.g., "I agree because...").<br><br><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod Audio Record in open ended questions                                                |
| <b>Picture Descriptions</b> | The teacher shows an image related to the lesson (historical scene, scientific diagram) or even a Nearpod VR activity, and students take turns describing it in detail, focusing on key vocabulary and specific grammar structures.<br><br><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod Audio Record in open ended questions |
| <b>Storytelling</b>         | Students share a personal experience or create a fictional story based on a topic from the lesson. They tell the story in chronological order, using the appropriate tenses and vocabulary.<br><br><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod Draw It                                                                      |
| <b>Think-Pair-Share</b>     | Students think independently about a question posed by the teacher, discuss their thoughts with a partner in breakout rooms, and then share their conclusions with the whole class.                                                                                                                          |

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| <b>Pair Interviewing</b> | <p>Students take turns interviewing each other on a specific topic (e.g., a historical figure, a scientific process) with prepared or spontaneous questions.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Virtual whiteboard</p>                |
| <b>Mystery Bag</b>       | <p>The teacher describes an item from a virtual “mystery bag,” and students must ask yes/no questions to guess what it is. The item can be related to the lesson’s content.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Virtual whiteboard</p> |

## Listening

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| <b>Cloze</b>         | <p>Students listen to a short audio story or passage with key words or phrases missing from a written transcript. They fill in the blanks as they listen. Maximize this activity by using key content vocabulary to fill in the blanks. For students who need a little more scaffolding, include a word bank. Below is an example of a cloze activity with a word bank:</p> <p><b>The Water Cycle</b></p> <p>Fill in the blanks with the correct words from the word bank.</p> <p><b>Word Bank:</b></p> <p>evaporation, clouds, precipitation, sun, ocean, condensation</p> <p>The water cycle is the process by which water moves through the Earth’s atmosphere. First, the heat from the _____ warms up water from the Earth’s surface, causing it to turn into water vapor. This process is called _____. The water vapor rises into the air and cools down, turning back into liquid droplets. This process is known as _____, and it forms _____ in the sky. When the clouds become heavy with water droplets, the water falls back to Earth as rain, snow, or hail, which is called _____. Much of the water returns to rivers, lakes, or the _____, where the cycle begins again.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Quickly create digital interactive cloze activities from any text, use MagicSchool AI or this free tool from <a href="#">Class Tools!</a></p> |
| <b>True or False</b> | <p>The teacher reads or plays a recording related to the lesson, and students decide if statements about the passage are true or false.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Polling feature in Zoom or Nearpod</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
| <b>Sequencing</b>    | <p>Students listen to a series of events or steps and must put them in the correct order (e.g., the steps in a scientific process or historical timeline).</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Virtual whiteboard or Nearpod Draw It or Drag and Drop</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>BINGO</b>         | <p>Create bingo cards with vocabulary or key concepts from the lesson. As students listen to the teacher read out the words, they mark the words or</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |

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|  | phrases they hear on their cards. Bingo card example: <a href="#">Bingo Card (5x5 Grid)</a> |
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## Reading

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| <b>Jigsaw Reading</b>          | <p>Divide a text into sections. Each student or group reads one part, then they come together to share and summarize their section, collaboratively piecing together the entire text.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod Immersive Reader</p>                                                                       |
| <b>Pre-Reading Predictions</b> | <p>Before reading, students look at the title, headings, or key images in the text and predict what the text will be about. After reading, they revisit their predictions to check for accuracy.</p>                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Graphic Organizers</b>      | <p>Use graphic organizers like Venn diagrams, T-charts, or mind maps to help students organize information from the text. For example, students can use a cause-and-effect chart for science or history readings.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Find graphic organizers in the <b>Language Essentials</b> slides.</p>  |
| <b>Text Annotations</b>        | <p>Teach students to highlight or underline key words, unfamiliar vocabulary, and main ideas while reading. They can also make notes or ask questions in the margins.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Zoom interactive whiteboard tools</p>                                                                              |
| <b>Partner Reading</b>         | <p>Students take turns reading parts of a text aloud in pairs or small groups. Afterward, they discuss what they understood and clarify any confusing sections.</p>                                                                                                                                                  |
| <b>Summarizing</b>             | <p>After reading a passage, students summarize the main ideas in a few sentences. This can be done orally or in writing.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <b>Cloze Reading</b>           | <p>Provide students with a passage where key words are removed. Students fill in the blanks using context clues from the surrounding text.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> quickly create digital interactive cloze activities from any text, use MagicSchool AI or this free tool from <a href="#">Class Tools!</a></p> |

## Writing

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| <b>Guided Writing Prompts</b> | <p>Provide students with sentence starters or prompts related to the content area (In today's science experiment, we observed_____).</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Zoom interactive whiteboard tools</p> |
| <b>Summary Writing</b>        | <p>After reading a text or completing a lesson, students write a short summary of the key points.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod open ended questions</p>                                         |
| <b>Write a Letter</b>         | <p>Ask students to write a letter related to a content area topic (e.g., writing a letter to a historical figure, a scientist, or a character from a story).</p>                                       |



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| <b>Collaborative Writing</b>     | <p>In pairs or small groups, students collaboratively write a paragraph, essay, or story. Each student contributes a sentence or idea, building on each other's work. Pair students up with a low-level writer with a high-level writer.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Google docs</p>                   |
| <b>Write a Dialogue</b>          | <p>Ask students to write a dialogue between two characters related to the lesson topic. For example, students could write a conversation between two historical figures or scientists discussing an event or experiment.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod open ended questions or chat features</p> |
| <b>Video or Podcast Response</b> | <p>After watching a video or listening to a podcast related to the lesson (e.g., a documentary on a historical event or a scientific concept), students write a response or reflection.</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod Audio Record in open ended questions</p>                                   |
| <b>Write a How-To Guide</b>      | <p>Students write step-by-step instructions for a process related to the content area (e.g., explaining a scientific experiment, how to solve a math problem, or how to prepare for a historical event).</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Nearpod open ended questions or chat features</p>                 |
| <b>Journal Writing</b>           | <p>Have students keep a journal where they reflect on what they've learned in a particular subject. Prompts can include "What was the most interesting part of today's lesson?" or "How can I use what I learned today in real life?"</p> <p><b>Tools to try:</b> Google docs or Otus</p>              |